

Nationalism in India

Social Science — History • Chapter 2 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

How does an idea — the idea of being 'Indian' — spread across a vast and diverse subcontinent of farmers, weavers, students, princes, women in homes, and tribals in forests? This chapter traces the growth of Indian nationalism in the 1920s and 1930s under Mahatma Gandhi's leadership — through the **Non-Cooperation Movement**, **Civil Disobedience Movement**, the **Salt March**, and the powerful imagining of India through symbols, songs and images.

The First World War, Khilafat and Non-Cooperation

World War I (1914-18) created huge economic distress in India: high taxes, customs duties, forced recruitment, food shortages and influenza killed millions. Anger boiled over. Several events sharpened it:

- **Rowlatt Act (1919)** — gave the British powers to imprison Indians without trial. Gandhi launched a nationwide **satyagraha** against it.
- **Jallianwala Bagh massacre (13 April 1919)** — General Dyer ordered firing on a peaceful gathering at Amritsar; hundreds killed. The country was outraged.
- **Khilafat Movement** — Indian Muslims (led by Ali brothers) protested against the dismantling of the Ottoman Caliph after WWI; Gandhi joined hands and made it a Hindu-Muslim unity movement.

Non-Cooperation Movement (1920-22) — Gandhi proposed a 3-stage programme: surrender of titles, boycott of government schools/courts/services, foreign goods; and finally civil disobedience and refusal to pay taxes. Different groups joined — students, lawyers, peasants, workers — but with different meanings. Sadly, the movement was called off after the violent **Chauri Chaura incident (Feb 1922)**, where peasants set fire to a police station killing 22 policemen.

Different groups, different aspirations

- **Awadh peasants (Baba Ramchandra)** — fought against zamindars demanding high rents and unpaid labour (begar).
- **Tribals in Andhra (Alluri Sitaram Raju)** — Gudum Hills; militant guerrilla movement against forest laws that denied them firewood and grazing.
- **Plantation workers in Assam** — workers left tea estates without permission, were caught and beaten on returning home; for them *swaraj* meant freedom of movement.

Civil Disobedience and the Salt March

The 1928 **Simon Commission** arrived without a single Indian member; greeted with 'Simon Go Back' protests. In 1929, Lahore Congress under Nehru declared *purna swaraj* (complete independence). On **26 January 1930**, Independence Day was celebrated for the first time.

The Salt March (1930) — Gandhi's master-stroke. He marched 240 miles from Sabarmati Ashram to Dandi (12 March – 6 April 1930), where he made salt by boiling sea water — defying the British Salt Law. Salt was a daily essential, taxed by the British. The march sparked the **Civil Disobedience Movement**:

- Country-wide breaking of salt laws, refusal to pay taxes, boycott of foreign cloth.
- Gandhi was arrested; mass demonstrations followed.
- Sarojini Naidu led a salt raid on Dharasana salt works; thousands were beaten.
- **Gandhi-Irwin Pact (1931)** — Gandhi agreed to attend the 2nd Round Table Conference in London; movement temporarily suspended; failed to deliver freedom and was renewed.

How participants saw the movement

- **Rich peasants (Patidars of Gujarat, Jats of UP)** — hit by trade depression and falling prices; fought hard but lost interest when the movement was paused without revenue revisions.
- **Poor peasants** — wanted unpaid rents to be remitted; Congress was reluctant to support 'no rent' demands.

- **Industrialists** — wanted protection from foreign goods; G. D. Birla supported the movement; FICCI formed in 1927.
- **Workers** — distanced because Congress was uneasy about labour demands clashing with industrialists.
- **Women** — participated in huge numbers in Salt March, picketing of foreign cloth and liquor shops; idea of 'national service' as womanly duty took root.
- **Dalits** — Ambedkar demanded separate electorates; Gandhi's **fast unto death** led to the **Poona Pact (1932)** with reserved seats in legislatures within a joint electorate.
- **Muslims** — many felt alienated as Hindu symbols dominated Congress; Muslim League under Jinnah grew.

Sense of collective belonging

Nationalism became powerful through symbols, images and songs. **Bharat Mata** as a calm, divine mother (painted by **Abanindranath Tagore**); **Vande Mataram** hymn from Bankim Chandra's *Anandamath*; the **Swaraj flag** (red, green, white with a spinning wheel — Gandhi); folk tales gathered by Tagore and others to celebrate 'true Indian-ness'; reinterpretation of history to recall a glorious past.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- Rowlatt Act (1919) → Jallianwala Bagh massacre (April 1919, Amritsar, Gen. Dyer).
- Non-Cooperation (1920-22) called off after Chauri Chaura (Feb 1922, peasants kill 22 policemen).
- Salt March: 12 Mar – 6 Apr 1930, Sabarmati to Dandi, ~240 miles. Started Civil Disobedience.
- Purna Swaraj declared at Lahore Congress 1929 (Nehru). First Independence Day: 26 Jan 1930.
- Poona Pact (1932): Ambedkar–Gandhi compromise on Dalit reserved seats.
- Bharat Mata painting by Abanindranath Tagore; Vande Mataram from Bankim Chandra's *Anandamath*.
- Swaraj flag — red, green, white with spinning wheel (charkha).

— End of Summary —